Checks for listening

Instructions, explanations and classmates

Use brief checks to establish whether students heard the instruction, key explanation point or contribution from a classmate. This helps distinguish missed information from difficulty understanding it.

How to do it well

1 Plan the message. Identify the exact instruction, definition or relationship students need to retain and make it concise.

2 Establish the routine. Explain why listening will be checked, secure attention and deliver the message without competing activity.

3 Ask for recall. Use question–pause–name, choral response or a brief written response to retrieve what was actually said.

4 Repair the missed point. Re-deliver or reframe it clearly, then check again; ask students to paraphrase a peer's contribution where appropriate.

5 Move to understanding. Give a fresh question requiring application or explanation. Students can repeat accurately while remaining unsure how to use the idea.

What this sounds like

"A catalyst speeds up a reaction without being used up. A catalyst speeds up…? Something that speeds up a reaction without being used up is…?"

Classroom example. An English teacher explains that the claim must be supported with a quotation. A pupil states where the evidence should appear, then another restates the key point from a classmate's answer. Those checks establish receipt. A new paragraph task then tests whether students can select suitable evidence and explain the connection independently.

Top tips that make the technique work

Teach the distinction. Explain that this question checks what was just said; a later task will check whether students can apply it.

Use Explain–Frame–Reframe. State a key relationship, ask students to complete it, then reverse the prompt where the reversal remains accurate.

Check peers' contributions. Ask another student to restate the idea before inviting agreement, challenge or elaboration.

Make the message accessible first. Secure quiet, speak audibly and avoid distributing resources or introducing competing text while delivering it.

Keep corrections supportive. Restate the short message and give another opportunity; hearing, language or processing difficulties must not be treated as deliberate inattention.

Do and avoid

Do	Avoid
Check instructions, explanations and classmates.	Using "Are you listening?" as the check.
Ask a separate application question afterwards.	Assuming successful repetition establishes understanding.

Further reading

Practitioner guidance; teacher language above is an illustrative BSCS adaptation.

Barton - Checking for listening | Barton - Embedding habits and routines

DistillED Habits of attention